Justinian Mugasha - *The Place You Come From*

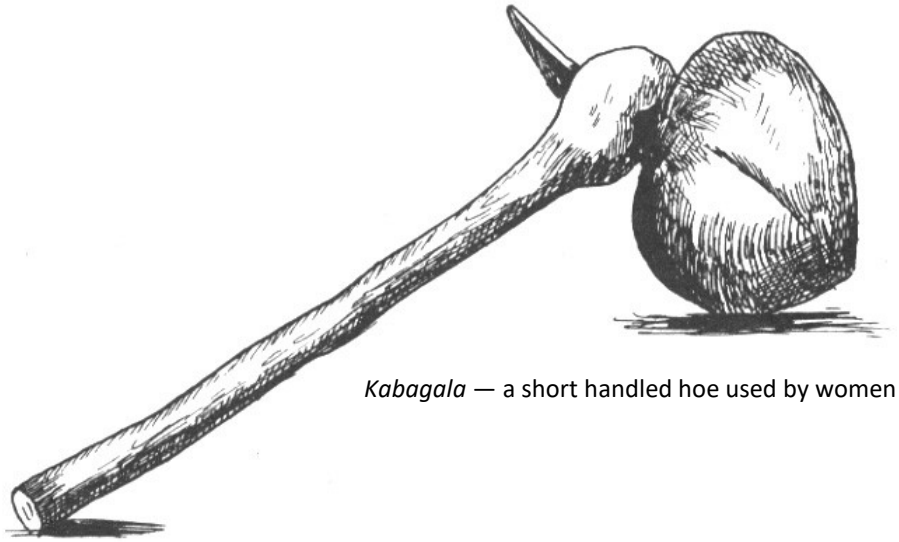
Translated and Edited by P.S.

The Place You Come From is rich in poetic imagery. Indeed, the proper use and interpretation of metaphor is the pivot on which the ballad narrative turns. As in the ballads King Kaitaba and Mugasha, the dramatic energy that drives the plot forward is released in a controlled, explosive, verbal exchange. A protagonist receives an insult that cannot be endured. In The Place You Come From, the exchange is poetic and is related to the genre called oku-shambagiza, "to evaluate a person or social entity through metaphoric comparisons." That evaluation is usually valorization, and the comparisons are usually praises. But in the present ballad, the comparison is insulting.

To prepare for that verbal detonation, to construct its dramatic and semantic inevitability, the bard surrounds events leading up to it with a rich filigree of cohesive poetic imagery. After the insult, first to compound and then finally to resolve the explosive conflict, the bard reveals a web of cultural associations that settles interpretation and grounds judgment, at least in this story. The ballad itself concludes with an extended metaphor on the principal subject that is as life affirming and mirth producing as the insult is spiteful.

The imagery and themes of the ballad come, of course, from Haya social imagination and poetic creativity, as these have been shaped for and by the ballad genre. The figures and topics themselves fit well in their performance settings, being near at hand and on the mind at a wedding celebration, a king's court, or a public bar.

Justinian Mugasha performed this before a live audience at a bar in Nyamugonga, in Kihanja, Kagera District, on December 1, 1968.



Kabagala — a short handled hoe used by women

The Place You Come from — I Was Born There
The Place You Come from — I Was Born There

"The place you come from — I was born there
The place you come from — I was born there
5 Tell me where you were born,
And I'll tell you where I was born.

You're from Lubya, I'm from Ijumbi.
Cow-sisters' children breed well together.
Tell me where you were born,
10 And I'll tell you where I was born.

I was born in Katoma *of kinshwi*,
You were born in Bulembo *of yojwe*.
Tell me where you were born,
And I'll tell you where I was born.

15 You're a child of the Ikanoni river,
I'm a child of the cattle roads,
The cattle roads to Itongo,
Ane others to Ilogelo.

You're a child of the Bigwanemba
20 *Of They-bellow-not from Lake Ikimba*.
I chopped a tree down in Ngalama, they say,
And the branches hit a house,
And twigs hit a house.

Mbali Oluga Niyo Nzalwa.
Nti Mbali Oluga Niyo Nzalwa.

"Mbali oluga niyo nzalwa.
Mbali oluga niyo nzalwa.
5 Olangambila mbali ozalwa,
Na `nye nkugambile mbali nzalwa.

Oluga Lubya, Nduga Ijumbi.
Obwihwa bumo buteg' ente.
Olangambila mbali ozalwa,
10 Na `nye nkugalmbile mbali nzalwa.

Nzalwa Katoma k' ekinshwi,
Ozalwa Bulembo bw' eyojwe.
Olangambila mbali ozalwa,
Na `nye nkugambile mbali nzalwa.

15 Oli mwana w' emiga Ikanoni,
Ndi mwana w' ebihongolelo.
Ebihongolelo bigya Itongo,
Binunju bigya Ilogelo.

Oli mwana w' Ebigwanemba,
20 W' Ebitabologa bya Ikimba.
Bahi nkatema omuti Ngalama,
N' amashanju gakatel' enju,
N' amatagi gakatel' enju."

Plot Outline

Lines 1-14:
The comic ballad The Place You Come from Is Where I Was Born concerns a brief, adulterous affair between a man and a woman who grew up together but did not marry. The man's seduction begins with his use of poetic images that evoke ideas of closeness and familiarity.

Lines 15-23:
The man continues to poeticaly assert the aptness of their coupling.

Notes

1: The first two lines seem to announce the identity of the piece. Like some other epics, The Place You Come From I Was Born begins in medias res with an important rhetorical encounter. Here it is a seduction, and its themes of familiarity and of praise foreshadow the events to come.

8: Children of sisters: This sentence is used proverbially to suggest that familiarity is a basis for sexual activity, the tenor of other parts of this verbal seduction as well. To my knowledge, the sentence is not used proverbially in conversation.

19: Bigwanemba: not known.

20: Bellowers: This is a reference to the emamba, the lungfish, whose symbolic associations with women are rich. Lungfish do not bellow when impaled with a fishing spear (even though they make a low barking noise when out of water). They are in a sense a role model for women whose bravery is to remain silent on their wedding night and in giving birth. The latter occasion is the only time when the flesh of the lungfish is not forbidden to women. Men eat lungfish freely.

21: I felled a tree in Ngalama: This is a common element of men's self-praise (ebyebugo), but cutting a tree here also has a sexual connotation which has to do with the practice of pre-coital clitoral stimulation known as oku-telatela. Associated with the Haya in general (by themselves) and with the cult of the Bachwezi in particular (in Cory__), the practice is said to distinguish human from animal procreation. It involves rubbing or lightly tapping the penis on the clitoral region to prepare for entry. In the poetic imagination, vaginal fluids stimulated splash on thighs like branches striking a house when the great tree falls.

Poetic Stanzas

1-2: couplet repeated

3-14: verse composed of three stanzas (3-6, 7-10, 11-14) all sharing the same final couplet, and all formed in **aabb**; their initial couplets cohere by repetition (3-4), semantic (proverbial) reference (7-8), and parallelism.

15-18: stanza in **aabb**; both couplets cohere by repetition and parallelism.

19-23: stanza in **aa**x**bb**; both couplets cohere by repetition and parallelism and are divided by an inserted line (21)

Stand still there, let me beguile you," he said.
25 "Stand still there, let me beguile you well.
You Ma Kilondo *of the Mountain*.
This is the greeting I would give you 'Sleep well?'
They'll think we have one father."

Ati, "Oyemelele nkulembe.
25 Oyemelele nkulembele.
Iwe Ma Kilondo kya Ibanga.
Ngye nkushul', `Olailota?'
Balimanya tuli ishe emoi."

"That little switch of twigs of yours," she said,
30 "That little switch of twigs in fours,
Whom did you cut that to hit?"
"I cut it to hit you!"
"Hitting, punishing me so! For what?"
"I punish you for your mistakes," he said,
35 I'm punishing you for your mistakes.

"Akashanju k' amatagiwe,"
30 Ahi, "Kashanju k' amatagi inai,
Okatemile kutel' owai?"
"Nkatemile kutela iwe."
"Naho nontela nontulaki?"
Ahi, "Inye nkutula amafu gawe,
35 Inye ninkutula amafu gawe.

I asked you long ago to be blood brothers," he said.
I asked you long ago to be blood brothers, you and I.
Child of the black snakes of Bunena,
I asked you long ago to be blood brothers."

Nkagamba katunywana,"
Ahi, "Nkagamba katunywana hamoi.
Mwana w' enjoka zilagula za Bunena,
Nkagamba katunywana."

40 "Go stand at the River Ngono," he said,
"Go stand on the Ngono's bank,
And I'll stand on the other Ngono bank.
They'll think us trees that always grew there,
Muhumula trees found there long ago.

40 Ati, "Ogy' oyeme Ngono, Ngono,
Ogy' oyeme Ngono nseli,
Na `nye nyeme Ngono nseli.
Balimanya miti ekamela olwo,
Mihumula ekashangwaho.

45 Again stand on the Ngono's bank,
And on the other Ngono bank I'll stand.

45 Oshub' oyeme Ngono nseli,
Na `nye nyeme Ngono nseli.

Plot Outline

Lines 24-50:
The metaphorical banter continues, as the man constructs figurative images of lovers and love-making and the woman answers with her own playful metaphors.

Notes

26: Ma is the respectful title of a married woman.

27: Have how you slept: a morning greeting, which, when said between status equals, connotes intimacy like that between siblings or lovers.

29: Play with a thin switch is a traditional form of dalliance. Also, the double entendre here partakes of the same associations as those in line 21.

30: Four-twigged: Four, ina, is sometimes employed in punning reference to desire, the verbal form for which is okw-ina.

36: Drink a brotherhood: Blood brotherhoods were the exclusive prerogative of men. The term is used here to refer generally once more to a form of familiarity and more particularly, to the region just below the navel from which a drop of blood was traditionlly drawn to enact the pact. The drop was placed on a coffee berry and eaten by one's opposite partner in the relationship.

38: Black snakes: This is said to be a praise for the blackness and smoothness of her body. Snakes are also the animating agent of desire; each person has one within.

Poetic Stanzas

24-28: stanza in **aa**x**bb**; couplets cohere by repetition (24-25) and semantic inference (27-28) and are divided by an inserted line (26).

29-35: alternately a stanza in annular structure - **abcba** - formed by pairs of repeated lines (**a**'s: 29-30, 34-35) contrasted with single lines of interrogative syntax (**b**'s: 31, 33) contrasted with a single line of indicative syntax (the placement of locutives in 30 and 34 supports this construction); and a compound stanza in **aab**, 2 + 2 + 3, formed by two couplets whose lines cohere, respectively, by repetition alone and parallelism + repetition (**a**'s: 29-30, 31-32) contrasted with one triplet (**b**: 33-35) whose lines cohere both by repetition + parallelism (33-34) and by repetition alone (34-35).

36-39: stanza in **aa**x**ba** formed by contrast between lines that repeat *nkagamba* "I said" + *katunywana* "let us swear a blood brotherhood" (**a**'s: 36, 37, 39) and one composed of praisenames (**b**: 38).

40-44: stanza in **aa**x**bb** composed of linegroups that cohere respectively, by repetition of "stand" (inflected in the subjunctive) + "Ngono" (**a**'s: 40-42) and by enjambment (clause in apposition, **b**'s: 43-44).

45-49: stanza in **aa**x**bb** formed by contrast between couplets that cohere, respectively, by repetition (**a**'s: 45-46) and semantics (**b**'s: 48-49) separated by a distinct line type (x: 47).

Plot Outline

Lines 51-61:
The man's verbal seduction concludes with metaphors for his desire, swiftly answered by the woman's figurative assent and its literal confirmation by the narrator.

Lines 62-72:
The lovemaking occurs outside the village in a grove of trees near fields where women do agricultural work. It proceeds from literal description to emblematic praise to metaphors for physical sensation.

Notes

47: Something: the referent is love.

50: My love: Baba, from iba "husband," a Haya term of address that signifies intimacy, is used in a unmarked way by a woman to her husband and between women agemates; its use from man to woman signifies an unusual degree of intimacy and undifferentiated affection (see also Kachwenyanja, lines 146, 368).

51: Slippery: praise for the smoothness of her body.

57: Mother: Mawe literally "my mother," is the respectful term of address for an adult woman. The corresponding term for a man is Father (Tata).

59: Kabagala: a short handled hoe with a relatively small, heart-shaped head. It is said to be the indigenous form of hoe and is sacred to Nyakalembe, the spirit associated with women per se.

67: Sleeping-sickness: This and the praise in the next line will be explicated as part of the story below.

He said, "I'll fling it to you–catch it!
It itches more than any rash.
It lames more than acanthus thorn.

50 Dear one, it's you!"

Smoothness of Kijongo, there
Where he had met her,
Ma Kilondo *of the Mountain*.

"Rather than eat your mother's food, I'd eat you," he said.
55 "Those who eat you have acquired a taste.
Stop tormenting me with neighbor's closeness."

"Mother, Mother *Dappled-cow*, *Oft-spoken-of*," he said,
"*Spears kill men*,
Hoes are ruled by Kabagala,"
60 "Father *who makes me well*," she answered.
And speaking so, she consented.

The two hid her yams in a mushasha grove,
Near where Kilondo had been washing them.
The two hurried and entered,
65 Undressed and lay down.

He touched her on the thing *Well-spoken-of*,
On the *Sleeping-sickness*, *Killer-of-cattle*,
On the *Plunderer of cattle and their offspring*,

Ahi, "Nzikulasile - oitole.
Ibabila zikil' obuhele.
Kazichumbagiza zishaga amatojo.

50 Baba iwe!"

Katelela Kijongo kulinya,
Mbali yamutelaine,
Ma Kilondo kya Ibanga.

Ati, "Olwo kulya nyoko, ndyaiwe.
55 Abakulya bakwegomba.
Oleke kunyis' omutulanwa.

Ahi, "Mawe, Mawe Buyenje Lugambwa,
Machumu gait' abashaija,
Nfuka itwalwa Kabagala,"
60 Ahi, "Tata Eyantambile."
Kayagambile yaikiliza.

Lyagya lyasheleka enumbu omu kashasha,
Mbali Kilondo yabaile nayogeza enumbu.
Lyatela lyataha,
65 Lyabijula lyanyama.

Yakolaho ahali Mugambwage,
Ahali Shotoka Nyamwita-nte,
Ahali Munyagis' ente nogwayo,

Poetic Stanzas

51-53: stanza in **aba** formed by contrast between lines composed as 0verb + praisename (**a**'s: 51, 53) and a single line containing an adverbial past perfect (**b**: 52).
54-56: stanza in **aab** formed by contrast between lines that repeat *lya* "eat" (**a**'s: 54,55) and a finalizing line that shifts domain of reference and is inflected in the negative.

57-61: stanza in **aaabb** formed by contrast between a linegroup that coheres by composition as praisenames (**a**'s: 57-59) and a couplet that coheres by semantics (statement and exigesis, **b**'s: 60-61).

62-65: stanza in **abaa** formed by contrast between lines that are composed as double verbs (**a**'s: 62, 64, 65) and one line whose verb is an adverbial past perfect.

66-69: stanza in **aaab** formed by contrast between lines that contain simple praisenames (**a**'s: 66, composed as noun or 67, noun + verbal noun phrase or 68, verbal noun phrase alone) and a single line that contains a praisename composed by parallelism (**b**: 69, noun + adjective; noun + adjective).

On the *Short face with a long nose*.

70 When he began the folding,
When he entered inside, he found bananas ripe to falling from the stalk,
And higher up, the thick sweet mash kneading itself.

"Mother, Mother, Mother, Mother," he said,
"Mother *Dappled-cow*,
Mother *Spears-kill-men*,

75 "If you visit, if you visit," he said,
"If you find I'm cutting firewood,
The axe I'll throw above,
The hafted-knife I'll throw below.
We'll just walk together talking.

80 You Ma Kilondo *of the Mountain*,
You *Little calf's foot*,
Mother *Flirting neighbor's eyes*,
Is this not desire? You possess me!
You possess me, you possess me!"

85 "Father *Canoe-pole of Itojo's ferryman Kyakushengo*," she answered,
That measures the river bottom without a struggle."

Ahali Buso bugufi Nyindo ndai.

70 Kayachwile kukunjagala,
Kayayatahile okuzimu yashanga ebihiise nibyehogola.
Aha igulu omulamba gw' omunene nigwekamula.

Ahi, "Mawe, Mawe, Mawe, Mawe,"
Ahi, "Mawe Buyenje,"
Ahi, "Mawe Machumu gait' abashaija,"

75 Ahi, "Kolija kolija,"
Ahi, "Kolishanga ninshenya,
Endyamiti nnage kinyalugulu,
Omuholo nnage ekibanga eifo.
Tugende hamoi nitufumola.

80 Iwe Ma Kilondo kya Ibanga,
Iwe Kalenge k' enyana nto,
Mawe Bishobisho bya njweli,
Tikwo kukwohya? Nombanda!
Nombanda, nombanda."

85 Na wenene ahi, "Tata Mushomelo
Gwaguleng' entolo gutaina lwango Gw' omwa Kyakushenga Itojo."

Plot Outline

Lines 73-84:
Then follows a kind of pillow talk. The man begins with poetic praise, then recalls his image of masculine labor (lines 21-23) to assert the strength of his feeling. He concludes with more praise and a comparison of his passion to spiritual experience (lines 80-84).

Lines 85-98:
Her response moves from metaphoric praise for male to declarations of passion parallel to his but drawn from a realm of female labor. The pillow talk ends with the woman's playful enunciation of the intimate greeting that the man proposed in his seduction (see line 27).

Notes

69: Short face, Long nose: Vulva and clitoris, respectively, account for this praise name for the female genetalia.

70: Folding: a lovemaking position in which man and woman sit facing one another; they are 'folded' rather than lying down straight. This is said to be the position characteristic of lovers rather than married people.

73: Dappled cow: Of the many named colors and markings of cows, this is said to be the most beautiful.

74: Spears: Love and desire for a woman can be said to pierce a man inside, and can prove a danger to him, as this and other stories attest.

Poetic Stanzas

70-72: stanza in **aabb** formed by contrast between lines that cohere by initial adverbial past perfect verbs (**a**'s: 70-71) and lines that cohere by parallelism: preposition + banana beer constituent + reflexive verb in present continuitive tense (**b**'s: 71.1-72)

73-98: passage composed of two verses (conversational turns: 73-84 and 85-98) with mirror structure; both verses have three line-groups: an initial three lines of address and praise, patterened by repetition (73-74) or enjambment (85-86.1); and two longer line-groups, containing vows of affection and a rhetorical question - 5-line compound stanza and stanza in the first verse, and 6-line compound stanzas in the second; in the first verse, the compound stanza (75-79) in **aab**, 2 + 2 + 1, is formed by couplets (**a**'s: 75-76, 77-78) internally coherent by syntactical parallelism and contrasted with a single line (**b**: 79); the stanza (80-84) in **aa**a**bb** ia formed by contrast betweeen lines composed as praise (**a**'s: 80-82) and lines that repeat "possess" (**b**'s: 83-84)); in the second verse, both compound stanzas (87-92, 93-98) begin with 3 lines of conditional clauses cohering internally as **aab** (87-89, 93-95); these are followed by 2 lines of subjunctive verbs with imperative force (90-91, 96-97) and finalized by single lines, one that begins with a conditional (92) and one that repeats a rehetorical question (96).

Plot Outline

Lines 85-98 (cont.):
Her response moves from metaphoric praise for male to declarations of passion parallel to his but drawn from a realm of female labor. The pillow talk ends with the woman's playful enunciation of the intimate greeting that the man proposed in his seduction (see line 27).

Lines 99-101:
The lovemaking concludes with action parallel to that at the beginning (see lines 63-65).

Lines 102-108:
She then offers a bit of food to the man like a snack informally shared among intimates or given to a child, but here presented honorifically. He begins to refuse it, for it might be below his social status, but he reminds himself of a particular proverb and accepts the food.

Notes

98: Have you slept?: The greeting here echos that in line 27 and indicates, perhaps, a momentary nap.

108: Impure: The taking of food in this situation might be considered impure because they have not washed their hands after making love.

And if you visit," she said,
"If you visit, if you visit," she said,
If you find me peeling plantains,
90 Leave them. I'll wrap them up.
Let those who wanted them put them on the fire.
And if they leave them, let them burn."

Ahi, "Na `nye kolija,"
Ahi, "Kolija kolija,"
Ahi, "Kolishanga nimpata,
90 Olibileka, mbifundikile.
Ababyohyile babinegeze,
Kabalibileka bikunune."

"If you visit, if you visit," she continued,
"If you find me with the milk already poured,
95 And in the dairy room I'm churning,
Just tickle my ribs, I'll spill it out,
And let those who wanted it drink water.
Is this not desire? Sleep well?"

Ahi, "Kolija kolija,"
Ahi, "Kolishanga naitile,"
95 Ndi aha lusiika ninchunda,
Onzigazigite ngashangaze,
N' abagohyile banywe amaizi.
Inye tikwo kukwohya? Olailota?"

The two lay down and arose,
100 Went and dressed.
Went and found the yams again.

Lyanyama lyaimuka,
100 Lyagya lyajwala.
Lyagya lyagoba aha numbu.

The woman Kilondo reached in her basket,
Took some nice kilibwa yams,
Placed them on a banana leaf,
105 Presented them to the man.

Omukazi Kilondo yakolamu omu lugega.
Yaihyamu enumbu ezilungi ezakilibwa.
Yaita aha lubabi.
105 Yamuteka omu maisho omushaija.

When at first he began to refuse them,
He stopped and thought, "I'll eat these yams.
I know 'The beautiful cannot be impure.'"

Kayachwile kuzanga,
Yayemamu ahi, "Kandye enumbu ezi.
Nimanya `Ez' omulungi tihagala.'"

When he'd finished eating yams,

Kayamazile kulya enumbu,

Poetic Stanzas

99-101: stanza in **aab** formed by contrast between lines composed as double verbs (**a**'s: 99-100) and a single line which is composed identically, but to which a prepositional phrase has been added (**b**: 101).

102-05: stanza in **aab** formed by semantic contrast between syntactically parallel lines that involve one actor (**a**'s: 102-104) and a line that involves two actors (**b**: 105).

106-111: compound stanza in **abab**, 1 + 2 + 1 + 2, formed by contrast between single lines composed as adverbial past perfect + infinitive (**a**'s: 106, 109) and couplets that cohere by enjambment and parallelism, respectively (**b**'s: 107-108, 110-111).

Plot Outline

Lines 109-120: The Call
The lovers part, walk a short distance, and then turn to call to each other. At first, they exchange fond allusions to their recent intimacy. But then the man uses literal speech and insulting imagery to boast his conquest of, and to declare his contempt for, his erstwhile lover.

Lines 121-123:
The woman responds bravely, attributing his disgraceful ethics to low birth and deploring the shame he has brought her.

Lines 124-134:
Then she disputes the aptness of his insulting calabash image by contrasting it, on the one hand, with honorific cattle-based imagery for the same referent, and on the other hand, with the literal meaning of the image. The man curtly insists the image is apt.

Notes

124: Drum: another vehicle for alluding to the sexual practice noted above, line 21.

Poetic Stanzas

113-15: stanza in **aab** formed by contrast in speakers.

116-20: stanza in **aa**a**bb** formed by linegroups that cohere by enjambment.

121-123: stanza in **abb** formed by contrast between a single line of narrative and two lines of quoted speech marked by repetition.

124-127: stanza in **ab**b**a** formed by contrast between lines composed as 2nd singular verb initial + praisename (**a**'s: 124, 127) and those composed as praisenames alone (**b**'s:125, 126).

128-34: compound stanza in **aba**, 2 + 3 + 2, formed by contrast between couplets formed by repetition and parallelism (**a**'s: 127-128, 133-134) and a triplet that coheres by enjambment (130-132).

110 The man was then descending,
The woman was then climbing a hill.
He called to her again.

"Mother *Dappled-cow, Oft-spoken-of,*" he said,
"*Spears kill men*."
115 "Father *Who-makes-me-well*," she answered.

"Into your *Broken-mouth-vessel*," he said,
"I threw a clod of earth.
It burst in there.
When you bear a child," he said,
120 "Call it *Brought-by-Desire*."

She wheeled around at once, Kilondo.
"You commoner's son, you've shamed me!
You've greatly shamed me! you've shamed me!

You took the *Drum of kings and men, the thing Well-spoken-of,*
125 *The Sleeping-sickness, Killer-of-cattle,*
The Plunderer of cattle and their offspring,
You call it *a Broken-mouth-vessel*.

It's not a keg calabash for fermented brew.
Nor a tankard for sweet mash.
130 What they call a *Broken-mouth-vessel*'
Is the resonator for the *enanga*

110 Omushaija akaba nasoka,
Omukazi akaba natemba akabanga.
Yashuba yamweta.

Ahi, "Mawe Buyenje Lugambwa,
Machumu gait' abashaija."
115 Ahi, "Tata Eyantambile."

Ati, "Omuli Mashayaye yawe
Egyo nakujungamu eikote.
Lyakabila omu nda."
Ati, "Kolizala omwana,
120 Omwete Kalesilwe-ngonzi."

Yakebukila kimo Kilondo.
Ahi, "Mwana w' omwilu, wangola!"
Ahi, "Wangola muno wangola."

Ahi, "Watola Engoma y' abakama n' abashaija Mugambwage,
125 Shotoka Nyamwita-nte,
Nyamunyagis' ente n' ogwayo,
Wagyeta Mashayaye.

Mala ti kishusi kya malwa.
Mala ti kilele kya mulamba.
130 Ekyobeta `mashayaye'
Luba lushusi lw' enanga

Plot Outline

Lines 135-147:
The woman carefully stores her yams at home and then goes forth to set things straight. She meets some men and makes her accusation.

Lines 148-162:
She tells the story of the encounter and the subsequent insult, and she recounts her arguments against his spiteful rhetoric. The men, however, voice their agreement with the insulting lover.

Notes

132: Split: Ma Kilondo's definition of a broken-mouth vessel is correct. These two lines repeat a saying that may be used conversationally to attack a loud or long-winded argument: "Nojuga nk' olushusi lw' enanga nilwo lujuga lwatikiile!" "You boom like the calabash of an enanga that booms though it's been split!" i.e., your words, although loud or many, lack substance, are hollow, have no meaning inside.

Poetic Stanzas

135-41: stanza in **aa**aaaa**b** formed by contrast between lines composed as 3rd singular verb initial (**a**'s: 135-140) and a single line with an initial direct object.

142-47: compound stanza in **ab-ab**, 1 + 2 + 1 + 2, formed by contrast between single lines beginning with double verbs (**a**'s: 142, 145) and couplets (**b**'s: 143-44, 146-47) formed by parallelism and repetition, respectively (similar to 106-11).

148-151: stanza in **aabb** formed by couplets that cohere by repetition and parallelism.

152-155: see note for 124-127

That's the one that booms though it's been split."
"Mine is *a thing Well-spoken-of*," she declared.
"It's really *a Broken-mouth-vessel*," he said.

135 She turned around,
Saw her home was near,
Climbed a hill,
Passed two farms,
Reached her forecourt,
140 Entered the house,
And her harvest basket left; she put it in the inner room.

She went out again without delay,
Descended the hill,
Crossed a stream,
145 Met two men, and then she began
"But that man truly shamed me!" she said.
"How did he cause you shame, Mother?" they asked.

"He met me on the path," she said.
He spoke of adult things and I agreed."
150 We came to lay down," she said,
And when we came to get up,

He took the *Drum of kings and men, the thing Well-spoken-of,*
The Sleeping-sickness, Killer-of-cattle,
The Plunderer of cattle and their offspring,

Nilwo lujuga lwatikile."
Ati, "Eyange ni Mugambwage."
Omushaija ahi, "Ni Mashayaye kwo."

135 Yashuba yakubuka.
Yaleba mbali alikugya omwabo ekab' eli hai.
Yatemb' akabanga.
Yahingul' ebibanja bibili.
Yagob' omwabo omu kibuga.
140 Yataha omu nju.
Olugega yasiga yaluteka enjulugulu.

Yakangayo yagaluka.
Yasongok' akabanga.
Yashabuka omugela.
145 Akashanga ayemeleile n' abashaija babili.
Ahi, "Kyonka omushaija yangola!"
Bahi, "Yakugozaki mawe?"

Ahi, "Yambuganganwa omu kihanda.
Yangambila eby' abakulu naikiliza."
150 Ahi, "Twaija twanyama.
Katwaija twaimukile,

Yatola Engoma y' abakama n' abashaija Mugambwage,
Shotoka Nyamwita-nte,
Nyamunyagis' ente n' ogwayo,

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 163-176:
She brings her accusation to a local court, but the judges voice their approval for the man's words. She brings her case to a higher court, but the result is the same.

Lines 177-181:
The woman begins to cry, whereupon the king suddenly appears and inquires about the source of her woe.

POETIC STANZAS

163-176: two stanzas repeated incrementally, composed of initial couplet (163-164, 170-171) that coheres by parallelism (verbs in every line in both initial and final positions); then follows a stanza **aabab** formed by contrast between lines composed as noun + modifier + verb (**a**'s: 165, 166, 168 and 172, 173, 175) and lines that repeat one another (**b**'s: 167, 169 and 174, 176).

182-83.1: stanza in **abab** formed by contrast between lines that begin with a locutive (**a**'s: 182, 183) and lines marked by internal parallelism that restate the previous line (**b**'s: 182.1, 183.1).

155 He called it *a Broken-mouth-vessel*.

I declare It's not a keg calabash for fermented brew,
Nor a tankard for sweet mash.
What they call a *Broken-mouth-vessel*'
Is the resonator for the *enanga*
160 That's the one that booms though it's been split."
"Mine is a thing *Well-spoken-of*."
"Yes," they agreed, "It's a *Broken-mouth-vessel*."

What was once a secret broke open now.
She travelled to the lower court and made her accusation.
165 All the chairs creaked,
All officials judged,
"Yes," they agreed, "It's a *Broken-mouth-vessel*."
And a royal kinsman also judged,
"Yes," he agreed, "It's a *Broken-mouth-vessel*."

170 She stiffened her resolve; she went,
She travelled to the higher court and made her accusation.
All the chairs creaked,
And all the elders judged,
"Yes," they agreed, "It's a *Broken-mouth-vessel*."
175 And the Prime Minister also judged,
"Yes," he agreed, "It's a *Broken-mouth-vessel*."

She wept. Tears fell,
Ma Kilondo *of the Mountain*.

155 Yagyeta Mashayaye

Nti ti kishusi kya malwa
Mala ti kilele kya mulamba
Ekyobeta `mashayaye'
Luba lushusi lw' enanga
160 Nilwo lujuga lwatikile.
Eyange ni Mugambwage"
Bati, "Ego ni Mashayaye."

Eyaba eli enama yayatika.
Yagya omu gombolola yahababa.
165 Entebe zona zakekela,
Abakungu bona balamula,
Bati, "Ego ni Mashayaye"
N' omwami nawe yalamula,
Ati, "Ego ni Mashayaye"

170 Yaguma yagenda.
Yagya omu bulange yahababa.
Entebe zona zakekela,
N' abazee bona balamula,
Bati, "Ego ni Mashayaye."
175 Na katikilo inya yalamula,
Ati, "Ego ni Mashayaye."

Yalila gatonya,
Ma Kilondo kya Ibanga.

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 182-189:
She relates her story to hm in more detail, explaining to the king about their childhood together, their plans for marriage, and the disappointment of these plans when her father arranged her marriage to someone else.

Lines 190-203:
She discloses that they met again just after she had emerged from bridal seclusion. She tells of their accord and then revisits his insult and her rhetorical defense.

NOTES

190: Come out: Traditionally, a bride is secluded for a period of time ranging from a few days, in the case of a previously married woman, to several months, in the case of a family who can afford to live without her productive labor.

POETIC STANZAS

184-186: stanza alternately in **abab** formed by lexical contrast between lines that begin in "He comes from" (**a**'s: 184, 185) and those that begin in "I come from" (**b**'s: 184.1, 186); and in **aabb** formed by contrast between lines composed as "come from" + placename (**a**'s: 184, 184.1) and those composed as "come from" + placename + praise (**b**'s: 185, 186).

187-89: stanza in **aab** formed by contrast between lines that are composed as locutive + adverbial particle +: "grow up" (**a**'s: 187-188) and a single line composed differently, that finalizes with "betroth" (**b**: 189).

190-193: similar to 148-151.

194-197: see note to 124-127.

She was weeping there, when the king appeared.
180 "What makes you weep, woman?" he asked.
She wiped her tears.

"O King," she said, "What makes me weep this flood and bellow and wail,"
Once that man and I loved each other," she said.
"We were young then. We were children.

He's from Lubya,
I'm from Ijumbi.
185 He's from Katoma *of kinshwi*,
I'm from Bulembo *of yojwe*.

'When you grow up I'll marry you,' he'd say.
But when I grew up, he was not allowed to court me," she said.
"Father betrothed me somewhere else."

190 He met me just come out from bride's seclusion," she said. "I'd spent a year inside.
He spoke of adult things, and I agreed.
"We came to lay down, O King," she said,
"And when we came to get up,

He took *the Drum of kings and men, the thing Well-spoken-of,*
195 *The Sleeping-sickness, Killer-of-cattle,*

Kayabaile nalila omukama yahabuka.
180 Ahi, "Nolizibwaki iwe mukazi?"
Yayelagaza amaziga.

Ahi, "Mukama ekilikundiza amaizi kuchula kubologa,"
Ati, "Omushaija ogu tukagonzanganya
Tuli bato tuli bana.

Naluga Lubya,
Ninduga Ijumbi.
185 Naluga Katoma k' ekinshwi,
Ninduga Bulembo bw' eyojwe.

Yagil' ati, `Kolikula nkushwele.'
Ahi, "Kanakuzile talaizile kushelela."

Ahi, "Tata yansig' ahandi."

190 Ahi, "Mbwenu anshangile nyalukile. Mazile omwaka gumoi.
Yangambila eby' abakulu, naikiliza.
Ahi, "Twagya twanyama, Mukama."
Ahi, "Katwaija twaimukile,

Yatola Engoma y' abakama n' abashaija Mugambwage,
195 Shotoka Nyamwita-nte,

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 190-203 (cont.):
She discloses that they met again just after she had emerged from bridal seclusion. She tells of their accord and then revisits his insult and her rhetorical defense.

Lines 204-219:
She recounts her ascent through the courts, the negative results at each level, and her final anger and despair.

POETIC STANZAS

198-203: see note to 128-134 (shortened by one line here).
204-214: mirror stanzas: introductory lines associated by repetition (204,205 and 210) followed by a stanza in **abab** (**a**'s: 206, 208 and 211, 213; **b**'s: 207, 209; 212, 214) formed as in 163-176, q.v.

215-219: stanza in **aa**a**bb** formed by contrast between lines that cohere either by repetition of locutive + *mala* "And" (emphatic) *or* as 1st person future verb initial (**a**'s: 215-217) and lines that cohere by parallelism, verb initial + praise-name (**b**'s: 218-219).

The Plunderer of cattle and their offspring.
He called it a *Broken-mouth-vessel!*

It's not a keg calabash for fermented brew,
Nor a tankard for sweet mash.
200 What they call a *Broken-mouth-vessel*'
Is the resonator for the *enanga*
That's the one that booms though it's been split."
'Yes,' he said, 'It's a *Broken-mouth-vessel.*'"

"O King," she said,"I was greatly angered.
205 I came to the lower court and made my accusation.
All the officials judged me,
'Yes,' they agreed 'It's *a Broken-mouth-vessel.*'
And the royal kinsman judged me too,
'Yes,' he agreed, 'It's *a Broken-mouth-vessel.*'"

210 "I came here to the upper court," she said, "and made my accusation.
And all the elders judged me,
'Yes,' they agreed, 'It's a *Broken-mouth-vessel.*'
And even the Prime Minister judged me,
'Yes,' he agreed, 'It's *a Broken-mouth-vessel.*'"

215 "And I was greatly angered," she said.
"And I shall wail, I shall bellow,
I shall fall into the lake of salt I weep.
To take my *thing Well-spoken-of,*

Nyamunyagis' ente n' ogwayo.
Yagyeta Mashayaye!

Nti ti kishusi kya malwa
Mala ti kilele kya mulamba
200 Ekyobeta `mashayaye'
Luba lushusi lw' enanga
Nilwo lujuga lwatikile."
Ati, `Ego ni Mashayaye'"

Ahi, "Mukama natamwa muno.
205 Naija omu igombolola nahababa.
Abakungu bona bandamula,
Bati, `Ego ni Mashayaye.'
N' omwami nawe yandamula,
Ati, `Ego ni Mashayaye.'"

210 Ahi, "Naija hanu omu bulange, nahababa.

Abazee bona bandamula,
Bati, `Ego ni Mashayaye'
Na katikilo inya yandamula,
Ati, `Ego ni Mashayaye.'"

215 Ahi "Mala natamwa muno."
Ahi, "Mala ndachula ndabologa
Ndigwa enyanja y' omwonyu.
Okutola Mugambwage yange

Then they call it *a Broken-mouth-vessel*!"

220 The king bowed his head in thought; he raised it up.
"You truly win the case," he said.

"Yes," he agreed, "It is *a thing Well-spoken-of*."
"Father's going to court my mother," he said,
Was going to hunt *the thing Well-spoken-of*."
225 "When I was born they kissed me," he said,
"They were kissing *the thing Well-spoken-of*."
"When father passed inside and I assumed the rule," he said, "they honored me.
They were honoring *the thing Well-spoken-of*."

"And it is truly *the Plunderer of cattle and their off-spring,*" he said,
230 "For when they demanded four cows in bridewealth,
They went. And those just born were carried with them.
And when they demanded a white sheep for the clan spirit," he said,
It also went, and with it nines of cowries."

"And it is truly the *Sleeping-sickness, Killer-of-cattle*," he said.
235 It bears syphilis,
It bears gonorrhea,
It bears tertiary syphilis, whose pain cannot be spoken."

"Bakagyeta Mashayaye!"

220 Omukama yainama yainuguka.
Ati, "Omushango nogusingakwo."

Ati, "Ego ni Mugambwage."
Ahi, "Tata kugya kushwela mawe
Akaba nagya kuhiga Mugambwage."
225 Ahi, "Kanazailwe banywegela."
Ahi, "Nibanywegela Mugambwage."
Ahi, "Tata kayatahize natwala engoma, bampabukya.

Nibahabukya Mugambwage."

Ahi, "Kandi ni Nyamunyagis' ente n'ogwayo kwo."

230 Ahi, "Kabamwendize ente inai,
Zikagenda. Zizaile itwalile.
Ahi, "Kabamwendize katanga k' omuchwezi,

Nayo yagendwamu eby' enda."

Ahi, "Kandi ni Shotoka Nyamwita-nte kwo.

235 Egila akaho,
Egila ebingolo,
Egila emitezi olubabililo tilwakugambwa."

Plot Outline

Lines 220-235.2:

The king ponders the case briefly, then rules in favor of the woman. He justifies his judgment by explicating the metaphors previously used in praise epithets.

Notes

227: Went inside: that is, died, in royal vocabulary.

232: White sheep: a sacrifice that is part of the ritual requirements of a traditional Haya marriage.

233: Nines: cowrie shells strung nine to a string and tied to the neck of an animal to be sacrificed.

Poetic Stanzas

222-246: verse passage of two verses (222-235.2, 236-246) whose 5 constituent units are all composed as introductory line (222, 229, 234, 236, 243) + stanzaic pattern (223-228, 230-233, 235-235.2, 237-242, 244-246), described immediately below.

222-235.2 verse of three stanzas which are introduced by parallel first lines (222, 229, 234), cohere semantically as judicial judgement, and together form an **aab** pattern by virtue contrast between their respective internal stanzaic patterns in **abab** (**a**'s: 223-228, 230-233) and in **aab** (**b**: 235-235.2); the first stanza, in **abab**, is formed by contrast between lines that begin with a locutive and a dependant clause (**a**'s: 223, 225, 227) and lines that cohere with preceding lines by chaining and that have "*Well-Spoken-Of*" in final position (**b**'s: 224, 226, 228; note that 224 is semantically rather than lexically chained); the second stanza, in **abab**, is formed by contrast between lines composed as locutive + "When they demanded" + animal... (**a**'s: 230, 232) and those that begin with "went" (**b**'s: 231, 233); the third stanza, in **aab**, is formed by contrast between lines composed as "It bears" + disease name (**a**'s: 235,235.1) and a single line composed identically, but to which has been added a relative clause (**b**: 235.2).

Plot Outline

Lines 236-258:
The king levies then fines for lower court judges who ruled incorrectly. He devises two punishments for the false lover, one corporal and one culinary. He declares the root of the man's transgression is ignorance.

Notes

242: Folding: see note to line 70

Poetic Stanzas

236-46: verse formed by a compound stanza and a stanza which are introduced by parallel first lines (236, 243) and cohere semantically as a judicial sentence; the compound stanza in **aab**, 2 + 2 + 2, is formed by contrast between couplets that cohere by repetition and parallelism (**a**'s: 237 -238, 239-240) and a single couplet whose coherence internally between its lines and externally with the other couplets is solely semantic (**b**: 241-242); the stanza in **abab** is formed by contrast between lines composed as locutive + "elder" + [verb] + number (**a**'s: 244, 245) and lines composed as "prime minister" + [verb] + number (**b**'s: 244.1, 246); (the same stanza is alternately **aabb** by contrast between lines composed as judicial role + number <11 (**a**'s:244, 244.1) and lines composed as judicial role + subjunctive verb + number > 10).

247-51: stanza in **aabb** formed by a couplet that coheres by initial locutive and enjambment (**a**'s: 247 -248) contrasted with a couplet that coheres by repetition of "hit 25" (**b**'s:249-250); the final line coheres with the preceding one by syntactic parallelism of a 3rd person singular near past verb in initial position and by semantic contrast betweeen these verbs, "lie down" and "arise"; line 250 is thus a swing line, as is 237, 216

253-58: stanza in **aba** formed by contrast between single lines that cohere by repetition (**a**'s: 253, 258) and a quatrain (**b**'s: 254-257) that itself coheres as a stanza in **abab**; its pattern is formed by contrast between lines composed as locutive + 3rd person plural subjunctive verb + direct object (**a**'s: 254, 256) and lines that begin "And" + direct object (**b**'s: 255, 257).

"How many judged you in the lower court?" he asked.
"Ten officials judged me," she said,
"And the royal kinsman was the eleventh."
"Let each official pay you ten," he said,
240 And let the royal kinsman pay fifteen.
Calling it a *Broken-mouth-vessel* shows
They know nothing of the folding."

"How many judged you here?" he asked.
"The elders were nine," she said. "The Prime Minister was the tenth."
245 "Let every elder pay fifteen," he said.
"Let the Prime Minister bring you twenty-five."

"You man! You!" he said,
"The one who called it a *Broken-mouth-vessel*,
Lie down. They'll thrash you five and twenty."
250 Down he lay. They thrashed him five and twenty.

He arose and grasped the king's knees for mercy.
"Stand again," he said, "Let me make it perfectly clear."

"So you'll know that you know nothing of *the folding*," he said,
"They'll boil *kagigi* beans for you
255 And *sholosi* beans that are black.
They'll cut *Bellower enshankala* plantains." he said,

Ati, "Olamwilwe bangaha omu igombolola?"
Ahi, "Ndamwilwe abakungu ikumi.
Omwami niwe wa ikumi n' omoi."
Ahi, "Buli mukungu akulipe ikumi ikumi,
240 Omwami akulipe ikumi na itano.
Okugyeta Mashayaye,
Tibalikumanya mukunjagalo."

Ahi, "Hanunju walamulwa bangahai?"
Ahi, "Abazee mwenda. Katikilo niwe wa ikumi."

245 Ati, "Buli muzee akulipe ikumi na itano.
Katikilo agobye gabili na itano."

Ati, "Iwe mushaija! Iwe, iwe,"
Ati, "Ayagyesile Mashayaye,
Myama bakutele gabili na itano."
250 Yanyama. Bamutela gabili na itano.

Yaimuka yakwata omukama amagulu.
Ahi, "Shuba oyemelele nkugambilege."

Ahi, "Kumanya otalikumanya mukunjagalo,"

Ahi, "Bakutogosheze empelege ez' akagigi
255 Na kyasholosi ezikwilagula."
Ahi, "Bakutemele Lubologa lw' enshakala.

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 259-273:
The king summons the woman's husband, who signifies his respect by voicing the proper praise. The king declares him knowledgeable and decrees a culinary reward for him.

Lines 274-281:
The king concludes his judgment with an observation that, were it not for its downward tilt, the vulva's call would be more compelling than the royal drum's.

NOTES

268: Dear one: The term baba is used here as an exclamation.

270: Plantains: Enshansha bananas are a fitting reward, for they punningly refer becoming happy oku-shanshamuka.

POETIC STANZAS

260-263: see note to lines 66-69.

265-268: stanza in **abab** similarly formed to that of lines 254-257.

269-73: compound stanza, 2 + 2 + 1, in **aab** formed by couplets (**a**'s: 269-270, 271-272) that cohere by internal repetition (269-270) by enjambment (271-272) and by shared final lines (270, 272) contrasted with a single line which puns to finalize the figure.

278-81: stanza in **abab** formed by contrast between lines that begin with conditional verbal inflections (**a**'s: 278-280) and lines that do not (**b**'s:279-281).

And they'll cook you mole meat.
You know nothing of *the folding*."

A name he called–the husband who had followed after her.
260 "I call it *the thing Well-spoken-of,*" he declared,
The Sleeping-sickness, Killer-of-cattle,
the Plunderer of cattle and their offspring.
I call it *the Short face with a Long nose*."

He said, "You know the folding."

265 "They'll boil *kamwami* beans for you," he said,

"And *kabanga* beans that are white.
They'll find you meat that's rich," he said,
"My friend, I say rich kidney or the richest of the brisket."

"They'll cut you *enshansha* plantains." he said.
270 Eat the *enshansha* plantains,
Because you called it *the thing Well-spoken-of*,
Eat the *enshansha* plantains,
Eat them, feel happy in all your body."

"But that *thing Well-spoken-of*," he said,
275 "*The Sleeping-sickness, Killer-of-cattle*,"
What caused its great misfortune was–" he said,
"Its roar was diminished by its downward turn.

N' enyama bakuchumbile ez' enfukuzi.
Tolikumanya mukunjagalo."

Eibala agyeta - iba akaba amuhondeile.
260 Ahi, "Inye ngyeta Mugambwage,
Shotoka Nyamwita-nte,
Nyamunyagis' ente n' ogwayo.
Ngyeta Buso bugufi, Nyindo ndai."

Ahi, "Iwe nomanya omukunjagalo."

265 Ahi, "Iwe bakutogosheze empelege ez' akamwami

Na kabanga ezilikwela."
Ahi, "Bakuhigile enyama eshaile,
Baba, nti enyama eshaile ez' ensigo anga enkolo ezishala muno."

Ahi, "Bakutemele ekitoke ky' enshansha.
270 Olye ekitoke ky' enshansha.
Olwo wagyesile Mugambwage
Olye ekitoke ky' enshansha,
Okilye oshanshamuke engingo."

Ahi, "Yonene Mugambwage,
275 Shotoka Nyamwita-nte,"
Ati, "Ekyagibuliz' obwaku
Ekaitw' okujug' ejumaile.

PLOT OUTLINE

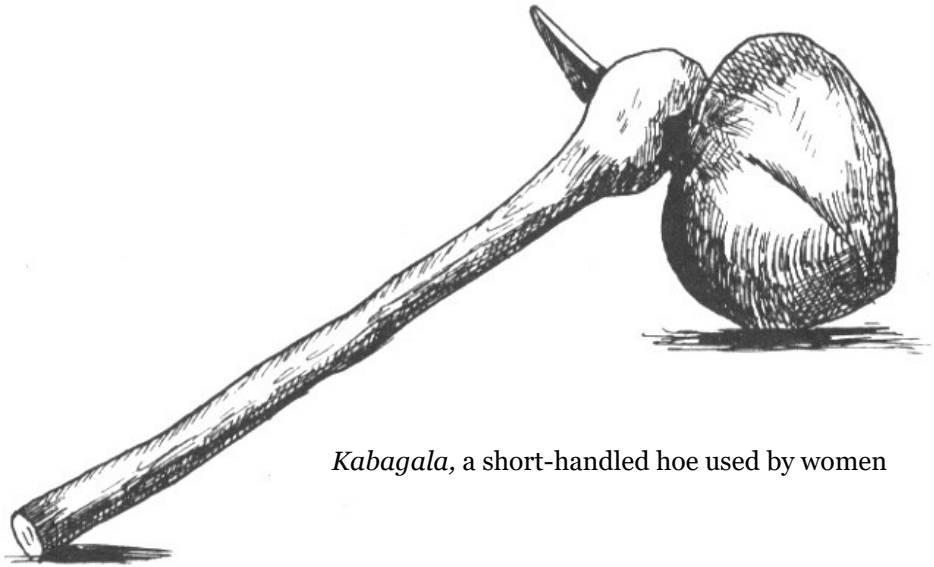
The king's final coment.

NOTES

281: Its call: This final image is based on the sexual practice alluded to before (see note to line 21). The sound signified by this drum's call is the liquid note of readiness. The loud audience reaction at the end of the song includes laughter.

Had they suspended it
Say, high upon the mountain at Ilogelo,
280 And had they put a drumstick to it,
Its call would have been greater than the drum's."

Kabakuba bagitungamize
Nka aha ibanga elihango elya Ilogelo,
280 Kabakugiteileho omuziyo,
Nekil' engom' okulaha."



Kabagala, a short-handled hoe used by women